

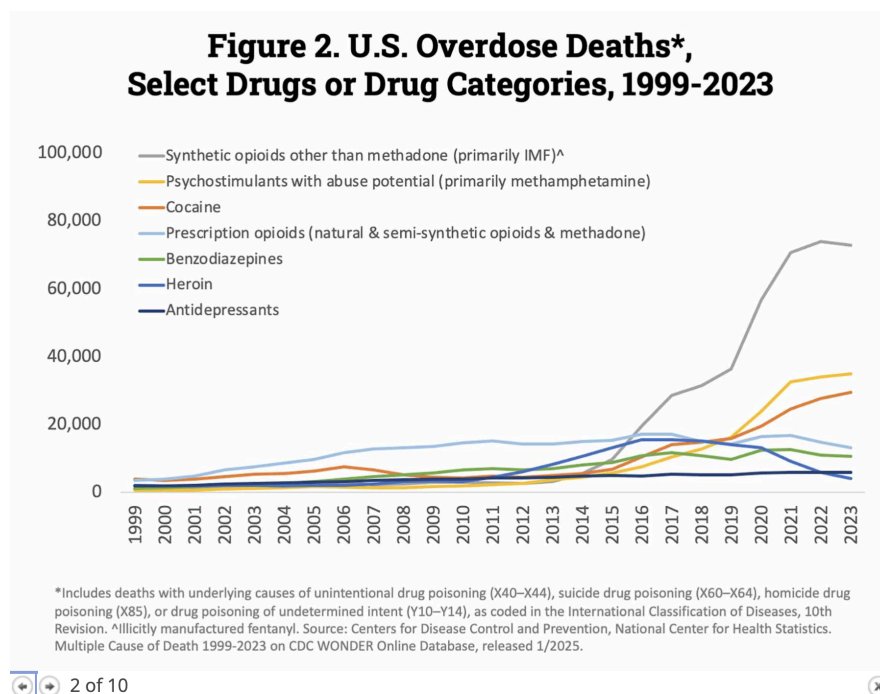
The Bronx Is Burning: Why the Drug Crisis Can No Longer Be Ignored

By David Daza Salcedo | United Against Drugs NYC

"This epidemic claims the life of one more New Yorker every three hours." Unfortunately, **statistics alone cannot capture the human reality behind this crisis.** One day, while walking around a park in the Bronx, I witnessed something unforgettable. A boy my age was sitting behind the trees in the darkness. The passing cars made some light appear; his arm was bound, his hand was shaking, and he had a syringe. It hit me right away: **there is a face of drug addiction behind all the numbers.** This face belongs to anyone and can be you tomorrow. In 2022, there have been [3,026 cases of fatal overdoses registered in New York City](#) .[“Drug overdose deaths have risen steadily for more than a decade.”](#)— that is, **the highest number ever.** [81% of the deaths](#) were caused by fentanyl poisoning, and the victims tended to be Black and Latino residents — **showing how the crisis hits hardest in communities already facing poverty, discrimination, and limited access to healthcare. This is why the Bronx has become the epicenter of the epidemic.** Addiction does not choose any social category — it just starts with a test. You might take this test for many reasons: once, just to see how far you can go, or to

join the group of your peers. And that's where many get stuck. **The drug crisis in the Bronx is not someone else's problem** — it is our problem, and it demands urgent action now.

The reason for founding United Against Drugs NYC is that there is an ongoing crisis of drug abuse in the Bronx. Our organization was formed to assist youth and affected families



through support, education, and recreational programs. The establishment of our organization came from actual demand. There was no shortage of that in 2020 when [582 people in the Bronx succumbed to overdoses in a single](#)

[year](#). The Bronx is the leader among New York City Boroughs in overdose mortality rates, [with 52.8 deaths per 100,000 residents](#). Among the affected people, Blacks and Latinos comprise the majority of victims. **These are not cold statistical figures – these are people**, our neighbors, our sons and daughters, people who need and deserve a helping hand. That is exactly what our organization provides. We try to help addicted individuals but also to aid their families, because we understand the reality behind every case of substance abuse – people do not go through it alone. At the same time, everyone is welcome in our safe, non-judgmental community regardless

of their situation. We offer a judgment-free space where every person is treated with dignity and respect, no matter their story. But our goal does not end there. Long-term, we want the Bronx to be a place where people feel safe — on the street, on the subway, in their community. We want to build a community network where everyone works together toward one goal: that there is a better life after drugs. That is the Bronx we want to leave behind — and United Against Drugs NYC is committed to building it.

The drug crisis in the Bronx has not gone unnoticed. Several organizations and lawmakers have taken action — although much remains to be done. One organization working to address this issue is [OnPoint NYC](#). This organization fights the crisis through a harm reduction approach, offering a safe and judgment-free environment for people who use drugs. Their services include overdose prevention, medical care, mental health counseling, and educational programs. In November 2021, they opened the first overdose prevention centers in United States history, located in East Harlem and Washington Heights. Since then, they have reversed more than 1,700 overdoses without a single death — a number that speaks for itself. The DEA also confirms that [“illicit fentanyl continues to be the primary driver of overdose deaths”](#), which reinforces why organizations like OnPoint NYC focus heavily on overdose prevention.

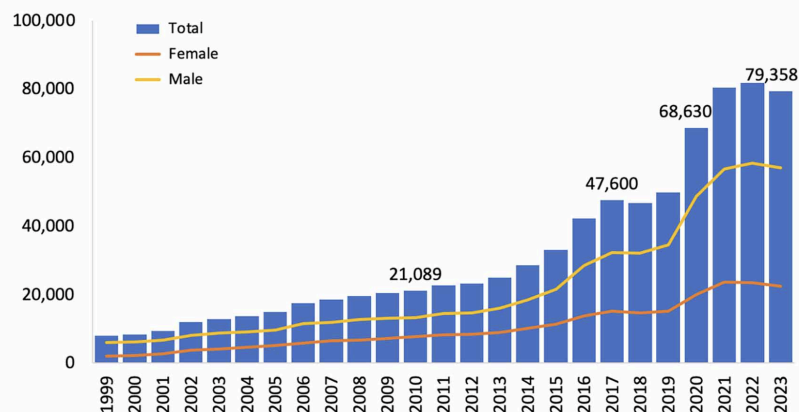
Another organization confronting this problem is [Odyssey House NYC](#). For more than 50 years, they have provided comprehensive services to people in New York struggling with drug addiction and mental health issues. Their programs cover not only treatment, but also family, housing, education, and employment — because they understand that **addiction affects**

every area of life. Their president and CEO, Dr. Peter Provet, has publicly emphasized the importance of keeping families together during the recovery process, something our organization also believes deeply. In addition to these organizations, lawmakers have also attempted to act.

At the local level, [Resolution 0314-2024](#), introduced by Linda Lee before the New York City Council, calls on Congress to amend the Anti-Drug Abuse Act of 1986 — also known as the Len Bias Law. This law, originally created to punish drug distributors with a minimum of 20 years in prison, created an unintentional but devastating effect: **fear**. People who are near someone suffering an overdose are afraid to call 911 because they **fear** being criminalized. **That fear costs lives.** Human Rights Watch reports that [“enforcement of drug possession laws causes extensive and unjustifiable harm”](#), showing how criminalization discourages people from seeking help during an overdose. The resolution proposes protecting those who call emergency services during a crisis — similar to ["Good Samaritan"](#) laws that already exist in other states. If passed, it could directly save lives, simply by removing that fear.

My organization, United Against Drugs NYC, will build on the efforts of other organizations and the government to create real change in the Bronx. Our first solution is to bring

Figure 3. U.S. Overdose Deaths Involving Any Opioid* by Sex, 1999-2023



*Among deaths with drug overdose as the underlying cause, the “any opioid” subcategory was determined by the following ICD-10 multiple cause-of-death codes: natural and semi-synthetic opioids (T40.2), methadone (T40.3), other synthetic opioids other than methadone (primarily illicitly manufactured fentanyl or IMF) (T40.4), or heroin (T40.1). Source: Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, National Center for Health Statistics. Multiple Cause of Death 1999-2023 on CDC WONDER Online Database, released

the message directly to the community through campaigns and park events. **We will not wait for people to come to us**

— **we will go to them.** Our team of three outreach workers will cover the streets of the highest-risk areas distributing flyers with impactful imagery and announcing nearby community events. These events, coordinated by a program coordinator, will include food, activities for children, and an educational presentation about the dangers of drugs led by a Mental Health Counselor. We start with children because **prevention is more powerful than treatment.** A Trainer/Coach will be present to manage activities and games. To implement this we need printed educational guides, tables, chairs, speakers, banners with the organization's name, and food for attendees. Because many low-income families need an incentive to show up — and we give them one.

Another way United Against Drugs NYC will help those affected is through direct street outreach. We know from experience that many people struggling with addiction also suffer from hunger and loneliness. So instead of waiting for them to come to an office, our team will go out to find them. A Chef will prepare daily nutritious meals that will be transported by a Van Driver across the Bronx four times a month. Three Outreach Workers will make first contact — offering food, hygiene kits, and clothing — because those basic needs open the door to trust. Once that connection is established, two Social Workers and a Peer Counselor — someone who has overcome addiction and speaks from personal experience — will sit with them on the street, in portable chairs, and listen. Not in an office, not with forms — but **right there, where they are.** Because many times what a person needs before any treatment is to feel that someone sees them and cares.

Lastly, United Against Drugs NYC will address one of the deepest causes of addiction: family problems. We will offer recreational programs — soccer, basketball, sports activities — coordinated by a Trainer/Coach, to give youth a positive space where they feel part of something. But we don't stop at sports. A Case Manager will individually track each person's recovery progress, while a Mental Health Counselor will work with families before the individual begins their process — because families need to understand that recovery takes time and that they will not be alone. Once the family is ready, we begin the detox process with family therapy sessions, academic support, job training, and daily nutritional assistance. For this we need sports equipment, a comfortable therapy space, job training materials, and daily meals for people in recovery. Because recovering from addiction is not just about stopping drugs — it is about rebuilding an entire life.

Drug addiction does not arrive with a warning. It does not knock on the door and announce itself. It arrives silently — at a party, in a moment of pain, in a bad decision made at the wrong time. And when it arrives, it does not only destroy a person — it destroys families, it destroys communities, it destroys entire futures. If you think this is not your problem, think again. How many times have you seen someone smoking on the subway and looked the other way? How many times have you walked past a park and ignored what was happening in the shadows? **Silence also has a cost — and in the Bronx, that cost is measured in lives.** I know this because I have seen it. I saw it in Colombia, where I worked in a foundation helping people who were struggling with addiction. And I see it here, on the streets of the Bronx, every time I walk at night. Addiction does not distinguish age, gender, race, or economic status. It can affect

anyone — even someone like you, even someone like me. That is why United Against Drugs NYC exists. Not to judge, not to point fingers — but to be there, on the street, where no one else is looking. To offer a warm meal to someone who has not eaten in days. To sit with a family that does not know how to help their child. To tell a young person that there is something greater waiting for them on the other side of drugs. [The drug crisis in the Bronx is urgent](#) — every three hours a New Yorker dies of overdose. We cannot keep waiting. If you can support our mission, do it. If you know someone who needs help, speak up. If you see someone on the street suffering, do not look away. **The Bronx deserves better — and that change starts with each one of us.**

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